

Auwa — To-Do List

Last revised: 5 August 2026, after the three-pillar pivot. The single list of what Tom and Rieko are working on, most important first. A few words that might need explaining are in "Words explained" at the end. PDF: [documents/Auwa-Todo.pdf](#).

What changed, in one paragraph

We have stopped work on the app. It was built and it works, but it would need months more effort and a marketing push neither of us wants to run, and even if it succeeded the money is poor. It stays online, quietly, and we can come back to it years from now if the character becomes well known. In its place we are doing the things that already feel natural: get Rieko's two books out, make and sell the figure, and slowly begin working with Japanese artists and craftsmen who decorate or remake the Auwa character in their own materials. Everything we sell is now something we own or something a collaborator makes and holds, so there is no stockroom, no shipping from Japan on our account, and nothing to manage while we are away. Full reasoning is in the business plan.

Deadlines we can't miss

- **Pay for the trademarks before 15 August.** The payment (to WIPO) must come from More Air. Miss this and we lose the international protection we've applied for. Nothing else on this list matters until this is done.
 - **3 September: a date to be aware of, no action needed.** A deadline linked to our design trademark. We only need to do something if the UK trademark office writes to us.
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The main focus right now: get something out into the world

We have spent five months making things and have sold nothing. Two finished books have been sitting unreleased for months, which is the worst possible state for anything to be in. Everything below is arranged so that we ship an actual object people can buy.

1. Get the books out — most important (Rieko finishes, Tom handles the route)

- Rieko applies the last print-test amends to Books 1 and 2.
- Send both books to **Colin** with one question: "Tell me honestly what you think, and what you'd do if this were yours." Two books together read as a series, which is a much stronger thing to show him than the single book he saw before.
- **Try a real publisher first.** A publisher gets the books into bookshops, into other languages, and reviewed. None of that can be bought, and all of it is exactly what we need, because everything else we're planning depends on people knowing the character. Give it a proper go, but set a date by which we decide, so it can't drift.
- If no publisher, we print them ourselves: print-on-demand as the always-available version, plus a signed first edition paid for by pre-orders.
- One more reason this comes first: **we can't approach a Japanese craftsman without a printed book to send them.** A maker who has spent forty years on one craft will take a beautiful book seriously and a website link not at all.

2. Finish the figure and sell the first batch (Rieko designs, Tom makes and ships)

- Test the eco-friendly filament, settle the finish, finalise the packaging (balsa box, ribbon, eco insert, hand-written card from Rieko) and the price.
- **Make 25 to 50, not 100.** Each figure is hours of printing plus finishing plus packing by hand, so a hundred is weeks of work before a single one sells. We never reissue an edition, so a small first one is a good thing, not a compromise. Sell out, learn how it goes, then make more.
- Use the "win a figure" prize draw already on the website to build interest before the drop.

3. Put up a simple shop (Tom)

A plain, clean Shopify shop selling only our own things: the books, the figure, prints, and paper goods. No other people's products, no stock sitting in our house beyond our own. Linked from the website and Instagram.

4. Ask Fin DAC to paint an Auwa (Tom)

He's a friend, he's already painted Rieko and shared it, he already has an Auwa stencil, and Rieko loves his work. He's also keen to be seen collaborating with and in Japan. We send him a plain white figure, he paints it, we photograph it properly and sell it as a tiny edition.

The real reason this matters: **we can't explain this idea to a Japanese craftsman in words.** Written down, it reads like we're trying to sell them a licensing deal, and the answer will be a polite no. We need a photograph of a finished one. Fin gives us that photograph, and every conversation after this one starts with it.

5. Write one journal article a month (Rieko writes, Tom edits and publishes)

The articles now have a job beyond search traffic: they are what we send a Japanese maker to show we can tell their story beautifully. So weight them toward makers and places rather than general seasonal pieces.

6. Keep Instagram going (Rieko posts, Tom on ads)

One account, not two. Rieko's five-day seasonal illustrations, the character animations, and now teasers and reveals of the figure and the collaborations. Keep the Facebook and Instagram ads running for email sign-ups; they were bringing in addresses at under £1 each, which is good.

7. Start writing to Japanese craftsmen — after the books are printed (Rieko, in Japanese)

Two or three makers, not twenty.

- **Never open with "can we sell your work."** Open with "can we tell your story": an article and Tom's photographs, made as a gift, theirs to use however they like. Selling anything is a second conversation, usually on a second visit.
- Send them a parcel: both printed books, a figure, and a one-page introduction in Japanese to Auwa and to Rieko as its creator.
- **Start with kokeshi and daruma makers.** Kokeshi are turned wooden figures that each region paints in its own style, which is almost exactly what we're asking for anyway. Then lacquer, gold leaf, ceramics, textiles. Knife makers are a much later conversation, if ever, and are better as a film than a product.
- Aim at working makers in the middle of their careers, or sons and daughters who took over the family workshop, rather than famous masters with years-long waiting lists. There's nothing we can offer a master, and asking damages the relationship.

8. Update the website to remove the app (Tom, separate session)

Three doors instead of four. This is a proper job, not a quick delete: "four ways in" is written into the homepage, the about page, the menu and the page descriptions. Keep the app page alive but

quiet rather than deleting it.

9. Reach out to people who can help (Tom, with Rieko for Japan)

- **LinkedIn:** a warm, proud update. No sales pitch.
- **Fin DAC:** publish the article about him, then send it as a friendly reconnection, then the collaboration conversation follows naturally.
- **Kyoto knife shop (Rieko, in Japanese):** share the Shigefusa article as a Japanese PDF with the photographs, hoping it reaches the knife maker. **A film, not a product.** He's too exclusive to ask for anything to sell, and asking would break the relationship.

10. Get our website onto respected design and Japan-interest websites (Tom)

Free design galleries: SiteInspire, CSS Design Awards, Typewolf, Godly, Minimal.gallery, httpster. Sites that share our taste, for a link and a quiet introduction: Nalata Nalata, Analogue Life, Rikumo, Tortoise, Kinto, Ignant, Remodelista, Freunde von Freunden, Hole & Corner, Kyoto Journal, Tofugu.

Later, but worth knowing about now

- **An exhibition.** Once we have eight or ten pieces made by different Japanese makers, that's an exhibition, and an exhibition is the thing that gets the character known in a way advertising can't. Start small: London Craft Week, then the Daiwa Foundation or the Japan Foundation, then Japan House in a few years. There are UK-Japan funding bodies whose whole purpose is paying for projects like this, and applying is free. Worth an afternoon once we have two or three pieces to photograph.
 - **Guided trips to Japan.** Five people, once a year, from 2027, with the two of us doing the first one alone. Before we ever take a deposit we need to sort out the travel regulations, because selling a package in the UK carries legal duties around protecting customers' money.
 - **Books 3 and 4,** more figure editions, and eventually licensing the character, which is the most hands-off money there is.
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Not doing (so we stop revisiting it)

- The app, until the character is genuinely well known. It stays online and unmaintained.
 - Selling other people's Japanese products. No stockroom, no importing, no returns desk.
 - Putting our logo on someone else's ceramic. It makes us look like a gift shop and earns almost nothing.
 - Printed t-shirts and general merchandise. Paper goods and prints suit the work far better. The 72-seasons print set or calendar is the strong version of this.
 - A second Instagram account for the shop.
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Words explained

- **Subscriber / email list:** someone who has given us their email address, so we can reach them directly. Different from a follower, who only sees us if Instagram chooses to show them.
 - **The Quiet Letter:** our email sent as each Japanese micro-season turns (about every five days), carrying one of Rieko's illustrations.
 - **Print-on-demand:** a printing service that prints and posts each book only when someone orders it, so we don't pay upfront for a big print run.
 - **Blank canvas figure:** a plain, undecorated Auwa that an artist or craftsman finishes in their own style or material. In the books, Auwa reveals the soul inside things; here, the maker's own work is the reveal.
 - **Kokeshi:** traditional Japanese turned wooden figures. Each region and each maker has its own shape and painting style, and people collect them. Closest thing in Japan to what we're proposing.
 - **Resend:** the tool we use to hold our email addresses and send our emails.
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Keeping this current: at the start of a working session, say "update the to-do" and it gets re-sorted, with anything finished moved to the "Done" list.